spend it—whether, for example, I wanted to proceed with projects or programs we'd had to curtail because of the deficit crisis.

"I think you ought to decide now," Cap said, "before the legislature hears about the money and starts thinking of its own ways of spending it."

"I already know what we should do with the money," I said. "Let's give it back to the people, give them a tax rebate."

"It's never been done," Cap said.

"You've never had an actor up here before, either," I said.

The legislature had to approve any refund of money to taxpayers, and if there was one thing I'd learned about government, it was that if there was any loose money lying around, the people in government would find a way to spend it. The worst sin in the bureaucracy was to give money back because it meant the bureaucracy's budget could be reduced the following year. If at the end of the fiscal year they hadn't spent all the money in their budget, there would be a rush to buy new office furniture, take a trip at the taxpayers' expense, or spend the money on something else, just to assure their budget wouldn't be smaller in the future. The idea of *returning* money to taxpayers once it had been collected from them had never come up before.

I knew what would happen if word leaked out about a surplus. Some legislators just wouldn't countenance the notion of giving money back to the people. To them, taxpayers were meant to be fleeced, not fattened.

Before legislators could learn about the extra money, I decided to go on the air and tell Californians about the surplus and suggest that it be returned to them. Since the surplus was expected to equal about ten percent of the revenue normally collected through the state income tax, I suggested the best way to deal with it was for Californians,